PROTOTYPE BRIEF · REDESIGNED EDITION

THE LAST LANTERN

A portrait dungeon-crawler roguelite: descend room by room, grow stronger, and decide when to get out alive

8–15 MINUTE RUNS · AUTO-COMBAT · EXTRACT OR PUSH · PORTRAIT

Design goal

Fast choices, visible power growth, low content burden.

Built for a small team and light monetization.

Reading Key

This edition keeps the original brief's ideas and adds detail:

- Untagged: from the original brief
- SUGGESTED My addition or fix, for you to accept or reject
- SOURCED Checked against a cited source (page 8)
- All art is placeholder SVG drawn for this brief



Town hub: one big DESCEND button



Run screen: auto-combat inside the lantern's light

Loop

Enter · Fight · Pick · Risk · Extract (p.2–3)

Meta

The town and its 4 buildings (p.4)

Economy & store

Three currencies max, light monetization (p.5–6)

MVP & research

What to build first, and why (p.7–8)

1. CORE LOOP

One Run. Five Beats.

ENTER — Choose hero › **FIGHT** — Auto-combat › **PICK** — 1 of 3 upgrades › **RISK** — Go deeper? › **EXTRACT** — Bank loot

The whole game should make sense to a new player in under a minute.

Why it works

- Frequent decision points
- Power increases every few rooms
- Extraction creates tension without needing a complex story

Prototype rule

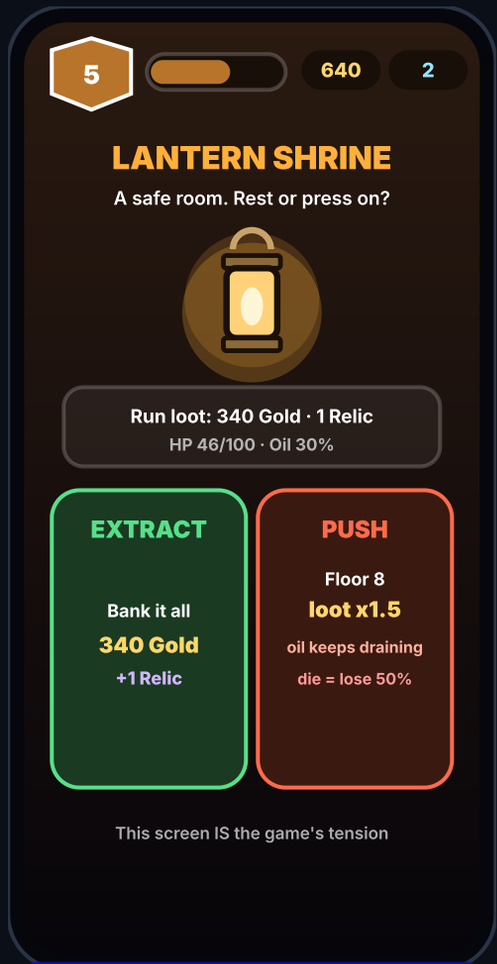
If the run isn't fun with one hero and one biome, stop adding content.

SUGGESTED Make the lantern the mechanic

The name promises a lantern, but the original never uses one. Proposal: **Lantern Oil** drains each room. As it drains, the light shrinks and more enemies spawn in the dark. Shrines let you extract. Oil is the soft timer behind 'go deeper?', and it gives the game a visual identity in screenshots.



Run screen: auto-combat inside the lantern's light



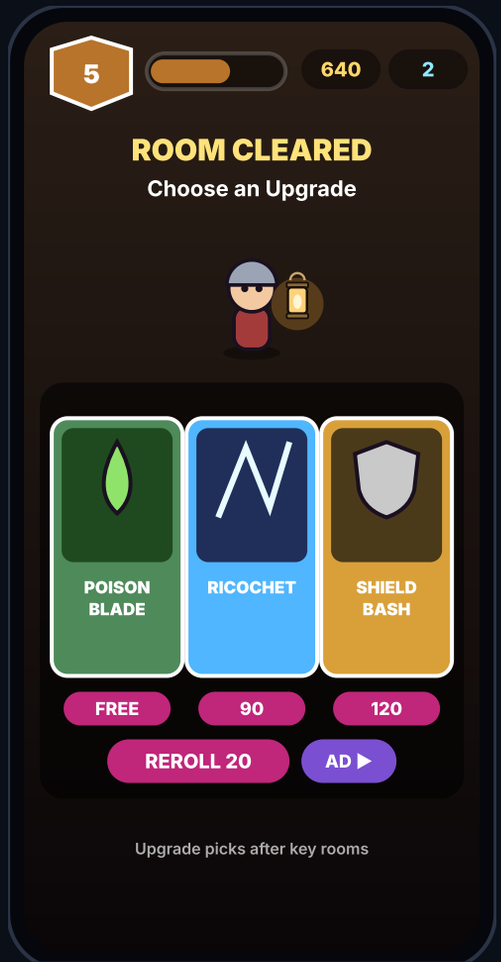
Extract or Push at a Lantern Shrine

2. RUN SCREEN

Combat Should Be Readable at a Glance.



Run screen: auto-combat inside the lantern's light



Upgrade pick: 1 of 3 after key rooms

The player barely moves; the decisions happen between bursts of combat.

Moment-to-moment

- Hero auto-attacks
- A small dodge or active ability
- Enemies arrive in short waves
- Upgrade choice after key rooms

Run tension

- Health carries forward between rooms
- Loot grows as the run continues
- Player can extract at safe rooms (Lantern Shrines)
- Death loses a portion of run loot **SUGGESTED** (suggest 50%)

Upgrade examples

Poison Blade (damage over time) · Ricochet (attacks bounce to 2 more enemies) · Shield Bash (blocking stuns). Each hero has 1–2 upgrade families it leans toward.

3. META LOOP

The Town Is the Retention Layer.

Permanent progress should unlock options without making earlier runs pointless.

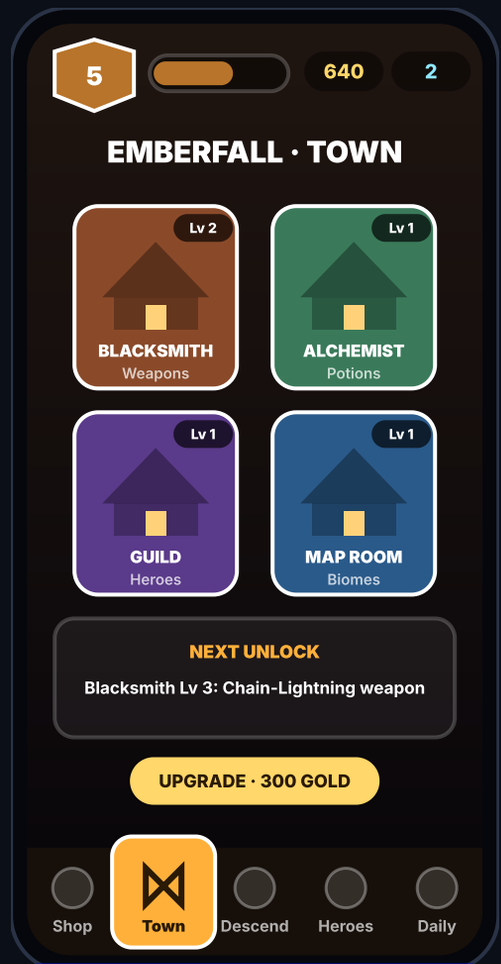
Blacksmith
Weapons: adds new weapon types to the upgrade pool.

Alchemist
Potions: one consumable slot per run.

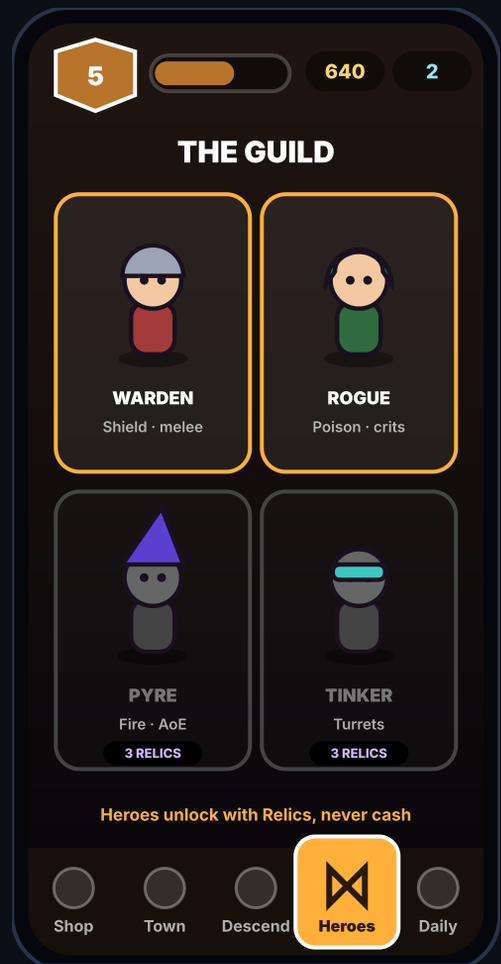
Guild
Heroes: unlocked with Relics.

Map Room
Biomes: the next dungeon and its modifiers.

Launch scope
- 1 town screen
- 4 upgrade buildings
- No crafting grid
- No inventory micromanagement
- Unlock more choices instead of flat +100% power



Town: 4 buildings unlock new options



Guild: heroes unlock with Relics

4. ECONOMY

Three Currencies Maximum.

Avoid the visual and mental overload of a mature free-to-play economy.

Gold
- Earned in runs
- Town upgrades
- Common / plentiful

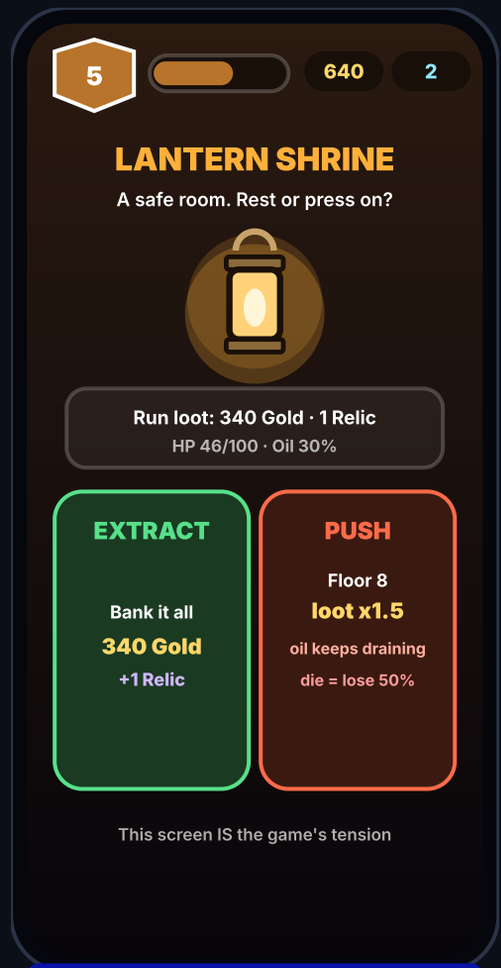
Relics
- Bosses / milestones
- Unlock heroes and rare systems
- Slow / meaningful

Gems (optional)
- Premium / rewarded
- Cosmetics, rerolls
- Never required for core progression

Retention
- Daily challenge
- Weekly dungeon modifier
- Short unlock goals
- Hero mastery

Avoid
- Energy timers
- Forced ad spam
- Five overlapping currencies
- Constant offer popups

SUGGESTED **Drop Gems** and price cosmetics in dollars, which leaves 2 currencies. SUGGESTED Lantern Oil is *not* a currency: it resets every run and is never sold, so it can't become an energy system by the back door.



Extract or Push at a Lantern Shrine



Guild: heroes unlock with Relics

5. MONETIZATION

Monetize Lightly. Keep the Game First.

A compact model inspired by mobile roguelites, without Cup Heroes-level pressure.

1 · Rewarded Ads *optional*

Revive, reroll or reward boost. The player chooses the moment. SUGGESTED
Never offer a revive ad *after* a failed Push; it undermines the extract decision.

2 · One-Time Support Pack $3.99–$5.99

No forced ads, a cosmetic and starter currency.

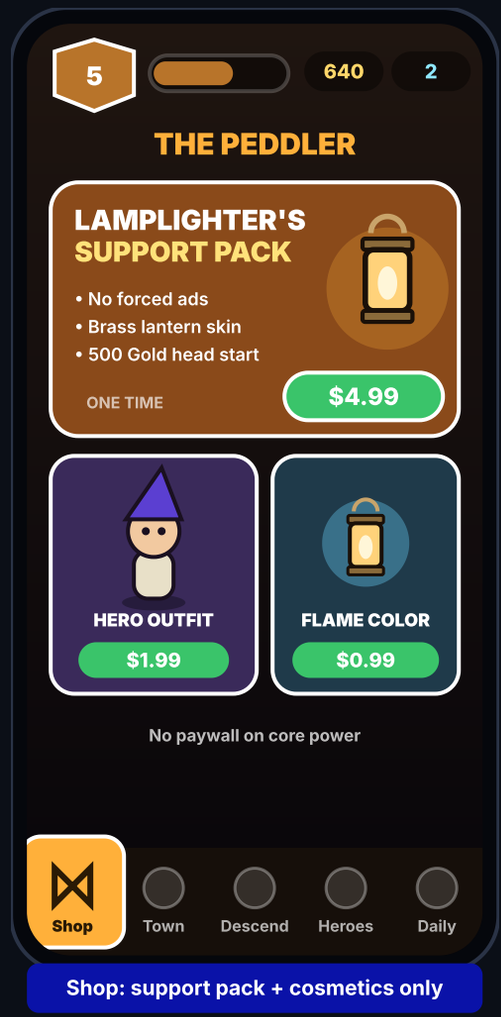
3 · Cosmetics $1.99–$4.99

Hero outfits, lantern skins, flame colors.

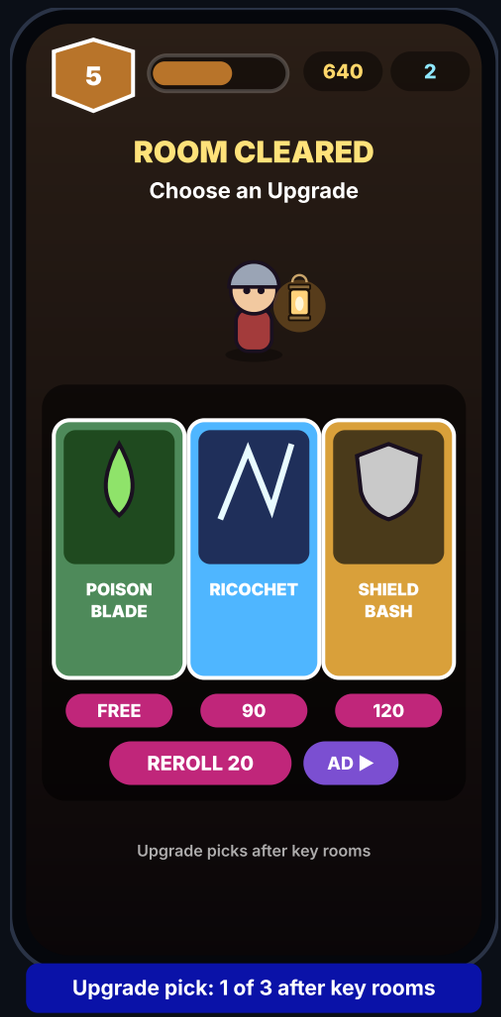
4 · Later: Mini Pass $4.99 / season

Only after retention is proven.

RULE: NO PAYWALL ON CORE POWER



Shop: support pack + cosmetics only



Upgrade pick: 1 of 3 after key rooms

6. MVP

Small Enough to Actually Finish.

The prototype's job is to prove the loop before any content pipeline exists. SUGGESTED **The list below is dungeon-specific (the original repeated the same list in both briefs).**

Build First

- 1 hero (Warden)
- 1 biome (the Undercrypt) of about 8 rooms
- 8–10 run upgrades
- 3 enemy archetypes: rusher, archer, brute
- 1 boss encounter
- Lantern Oil + 1 Shrine extract screen
- 1 town screen with 2 working buildings

Add After Fun

- 3 more heroes (Rogue, Pyre, Tinker)
- 2 more biomes
- Daily challenge + weekly modifier
- Cosmetics
- Rewarded ads
- Support pack

Do Not Build Yet

- Guilds (social)
- PvP
- 50 characters
- Complex crafting
- Large battle pass
- Live economy events

TARGET: A PLAYABLE LOOP BEFORE A CONTENT PIPELINE

SUGGESTED **A clear pass/fail test for the prototype:** do testers hesitate at the Shrine? If everyone always extracts (or always pushes), the risk numbers are wrong. Tune those before adding content.

7. RESEARCH ANCHORS

Why the Dungeon Crawler Made the Cut

Hades II

SOURCED Full launch September 25, 2025. Steam: **Overwhelmingly Positive (~95%)**, ~114K reviews in late-2025 snapshots; peak of **112,947** concurrent players (SteamDB, via wnhub).

Mobile dungeon crawlers at small scale

SOURCED **Soul Knight**: $0.99–$3.99 IAPs, ~$400K/month (Adapty estimate). **Shattered Pixel Dungeon**: solo developer, no ads or IAP, cosmetic supporter extras (Flathub).

Roguelikes growing on mobile

SOURCED AppMagic: roguelike titles grew **26.2% year over year** in 2025, while RPG revenue overall fell 17%. Sensor Tower: **$82B** mobile IAP in 2025.

Corrections to the original brief: it cites Hades II with '124K+ reviews'. The snapshots I could find show ~114K in late 2025, so 124K is plausible by now, but I couldn't confirm it. More importantly, Hades II is a premium console/PC game made by an experienced studio. It shows that players love the genre, not that it can be sold on mobile with light monetization. The mobile examples in the middle panel are better evidence for the model you want.

Why this one is the safer bet: unlike space, dungeon crawlers have mobile evidence at *both* ends: heavy (Archero 2) and light (Soul Knight, Shattered Pixel Dungeon). The extract-or-push hook and the lantern visual are what will make it stand out.

1. wnhub.io: Hades 2 peaks above 112,000 players on Steam (SteamDB)
   https://wnhub.io/news/stores-and-publishing/item-48951
2. GameGeeker: Hades II Steam review snapshot
   https://gamegeeker.com/games/hades-ii?market=PL
3. Outlook Respawn: Hades 2 OpenCritic 95
   https://respawn.outlookindia.com/gaming/gaming-news/hades-2-opencritic-score-hits-95-joins-in-elite-tier
4. Adapty: Soul Knight revenue/IAP estimate
   https://adapty.io/paywall-library/soul-knight/
5. Flathub: Shattered Pixel Dungeon
   https://flathub.org/sv/apps/com.shatteredpixel.shatteredpixeldungeon
6. AppMagic 2025 monetization report (summary)
   https://gamedevreports.substack.com/p/appmagic-mobile-games-monetization